JUGGLiN

For Four Players

A standard-deck Tarock game for four,
where the Declarer calls a King and the Pagat beats the Fool

Designed by Jonathan Ratschat

About 60 minutes • Version 0.2 • 8 November 2026

Concept

Jugglin is a point-trick game for four with a standard deck of 52 cards and its two Jokers. The Jokers, the Aces, and the 2s to 5s are the **tarocks**, which are permanent trumps.

Players bid on how many talon cards they want. The fewer cards, the higher the bid. The auction winner becomes the **Declarer**. In a **Point game**, the Declarer calls a King, and whoever holds it becomes their secret **partner**. Together they need 39 of the 76 card points against the other two players, the **Defenders**. If nobody bids, everyone plays **Ramsch** alone.

The deck holds two Fools, two Monds, and two Pagats, the Honours of the game. A Pagat, normally the lowest tarock, beats a Fool whenever they meet in a trick. This is the **Juggler's Trick**.

Every deal is played for chips. In a Point game, certain **moments** also pay immediately to the winner of a trick, such as a King meeting its Queen or one Honour capturing another. After three rounds, the player with the most chips wins.

Setup

Players: 4.

Cards: A standard deck of 52 cards and its two Jokers, 54 cards in all. The Jokers, the Aces, and the 2s to 5s are the 22 tarocks. The other 32 cards are the suit cards.

Chips: All payments in these rules are counted in chips. The best way to play is with poker chips or tokens worth 1 and 5, about 300 chips' worth in total. Each player starts with **50 chips**. All other chips stay in the box as the **bank**. Without poker chips, keep score on paper (see Keeping Score).

Board: Optional. It lies in the middle of the table as a play aid. A coin on it marks the contract.

Direction: Dealing, bidding, and play go clockwise.

Dealer: Choose the first dealer at random. After each deal, the player to the dealer's left deals next.

Forehand: The player to the dealer's left. Forehand bids first and leads the first trick.

Match: A match is **3 rounds**. In each round, every player deals once, so a match has 12 deals.

A Deal at a Glance

Each deal follows these steps. The sections below explain each one.

1. **Deal:** 6 cards face down as the talon, then 12 cards to each player.
2. **Auction:** Forehand first. Bid higher (Three, Two, One, Zero) or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.
3. **Talon:** In Three, Two, or One, turn it face up. The Declarer takes a group and discards as many cards, tarocks face up. The rest, or the whole talon in Zero, counts for the Defenders. In Ramsch, it stays face down.
4. **Partner:** The Declarer calls a King. Its holder becomes their secret partner.
5. **Tricks:** Forehand leads. In a Point game, pay the moments after each trick. After the trick with the called King, partners exchange one card.
6. **Settling:** The sides settle the game. In Ramsch, each player pays everyone with fewer card points.

Cards

Tarocks: The 22 tarocks are permanent trumps. From high to low, they rank:

1. The two Jokers, the **Fools**.
2. The two black Aces, the **Monds**.
3. The 5s, 4s, 3s, and 2s, by number. Between two cards of the same number, the black card beats the red one. For example, a red 5 beats a black 4, and a black 4 beats a red 4.
4. The two red Aces, the **Pagats**.

The black Aces play high and the red Aces play low. The Fools, the Monds, and the Pagats are the **Honours**.

Suits: Each suit has eight suit cards. From high to low, they rank King, Queen, Jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6. An Ace or a card from 2 to 5 is always a tarock, never a suit card.

Twins: Two tarocks of the same number and colour are twins, for example the two black Aces, or the 5 of clubs and the 5 of spades. The two Jokers are twins as well. Between twins in the same trick, the one played first ranks higher.

The Juggler's Trick: When a Fool and a Pagat are in the same trick, the Pagat wins it, whatever else is in the trick. With twin Pagats, the one played first wins. This is the only exception to the ranking. Against every other card, both rank as above.

Honour cycle: When an Honour wins a trick, it captures every other Honour in that trick. For example, the Pagat captures the Fool, the Fool captures the Mond, and the Mond captures the Pagat. A twin can also capture its twin. In a Point game, each capture pays (see Moments).

Card points: Table 1 lists the card points. Each trick won is worth 1 card point. Talon cards and discards count only the card points of their cards, never as a trick. A complete deal has 76 card points: 64 on the cards and 12 from the tricks.

Deal

The dealer shuffles, and the player to the dealer's right cuts. The dealer places the top **6 cards** face down as the **talon** without changing their order. Then the dealer deals packets of 6 cards, starting with Forehand, until each player has **12 cards**.

Before the auction, a player who has no tarocks shows

Table 1: Card points

Card	Card points
Honours: Fools, Monds, Pagats	4
King	4
Queen	3
Jack	2
10	1
Any other card	0
Each trick won	1
Total	76

their hand, and the same dealer deals again.

Auction

Forehand speaks first, then the auction goes clockwise. On your turn, either bid higher than the current bid, or pass. The first bid can be any bid. Once you pass, you are out of the auction for this deal.

There are four bids, listed from lowest to highest in Table 2. The number tells how many talon cards the Declarer takes.

Table 2: Bids

Bid	Talon cards	Bid value
Three	3	2
Two	2	4
One	1	6
Zero	None	10

The auction ends when three players have passed and the fourth has bid. That player becomes the **Declarer** with their last bid. If all four players pass, play **Ramsch**.

Example: A is Forehand. A bids Three, B bids Two, and C and D pass. A bids One, and B passes. A is the Declarer with One.

Talon

In Three, Two, and One, turn the six talon cards face up without changing their order. They form consecutive groups: two groups of 3 in Three, three groups of 2 in Two, or six single cards in One.

The Declarer takes one group into their hand and then discards the same number of cards onto their trick pile. Kings and Honours may not be discarded. Discarded tarocks are placed face up, so every player sees them. Other discards go face down. The remaining talon cards are set aside face down. They count for the Defenders at the end of the deal.

In **Zero**, the talon is set aside face down without being seen by anyone. It counts for the Defenders at the end of the deal, unless the called King is in it (see Calling a King).

In **Ramsch**, the talon stays face down in the middle of the table until the winners of the first six tricks take its cards as gifts (see Ramsch).

Point Game

After the talon, the Declarer calls a King (see Calling a King). The Declarer's side wins with at least 39 card points. Every deal is a Point game unless all players pass and play Ramsch.

Calling a King

In a Point game, the Declarer names a suit, for example "the King of hearts". The player who holds that King becomes the Declarer's **partner** but says nothing. The Declarer and the partner form the **Declarer's side**. The other two players are the **Defenders**.

Playing alone: You play alone if you call a King you hold yourself, or a King among the talon cards. A King called from your hand keeps it secret until you play it. If you hold all four Kings, you must call one of them.

Zero: The talon stays unseen, so the called King may lie in it. Then the Declarer plays alone, and nobody knows it until the end of the deal. In return, the talon counts for the Declarer.

Sides: The sides become known when the called King is played, or at once if it is among the face-up talon cards. If the called King is never played, the sides become known at the end of the deal.

Exchange: When the called King is played and two play against two, the partners on each side **exchange** one card after that trick. Each player picks a card from their hand and passes it face down to their partner, all four at the same time: the Declarer and the partner, and the two Defenders. Then the winner of the trick leads as usual. There is no exchange when the Declarer plays alone, or when the called King is played in the 12th trick.

After the exchange, a player may hold a suit they could not follow earlier. That is not a mistake.

Trick Play

First lead: Forehand leads the first trick, also in Ramsch.

Following: Play goes clockwise. You must play a card of the led suit if you can. If you cannot, you must play a tarock if you can. If you can do neither, play any card. When a tarock is led, you must play a tarock if you can, and doing so counts as following suit.

Winning: The highest tarock wins the trick, but if the trick contains a Fool and a Pagat, the Pagat wins. Between twins, the one played first ranks higher. If the trick has no tarock, the highest card of the led suit wins. The winner leads the next trick.

Point game: There is no duty to beat the cards already played.

Negative rules: In Ramsch, two more rules apply to all players. A card **beats the trick so far** when it would win the trick if no more cards were played. A twin never beats its twin. Your **legal cards** are the cards that Following allows.

1. If one of your legal cards beats the trick so far, you must play such a card.
2. You may only play a Pagat when a Fool is in the trick and no Pagat is in it yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats. This also applies when you lead.

Rule 2 keeps the Pagats back for catching a Fool. They cannot be used as a cheap trump or a safe low tarock.

Trick piles: Every player keeps their own trick pile. At the end of the deal, each side puts its piles together.

Moments

Moments pay as soon as a trick is complete, before it is taken (Table 3). They apply only in Point games, never in Ramsch.

Opponents: Moments only pay between opponents, which are players on different sides.

Hold: Until the called King is played, nobody knows the sides, so payments wait. Every player who would pay an opponent places the chips in front of them, apart from their stack, toward the trick's winner: to their left, straight ahead, or to their right. The trick in which the called King is played already pays directly. Once the King is played, hand held chips to opponents and take back the rest. From then on, moments pay directly. If the called King is never played, sort out the held chips at the end of the deal.

Who pays: The trick's winner collects every payment and never pays. The owner of the Queen, the King, the captured Honour, or a Pagat that loses the 12th trick pays, if they are an opponent of the winner. When a Pagat wins the 12th trick, the winner's opponents pay. While the sides are hidden, payers hold their chips (see Hold).

Calling: Before taking the trick, its winner calls out the moments in it, and the payers pay or hold at once. Until the next card is led, any player may still call a missed moment.

Table 3: Moments

Moment	In a trick	Payment
Queen's Ransom	A King and the Queen of its suit.	The Queen's owner pays 1.
Fallen King	A led King, won by another player.	Its owner pays 1.
Honour Capture	An Honour captured by another Honour.	Its owner pays 2.
Pagat Ultimo	A Pagat in the 12th trick.	If it wins, each opponent pays 1, a lone Declarer 3. If it loses, its owner pays 2.

Queen's Ransom: A trick contains a King and the Queen of the same suit. The Queen's owner pays the trick's winner **1 chip** as her ransom.

Fallen King: When you lead a King and another player wins the trick, you pay the trick's winner **1 chip**. Only a led King counts. A King played to someone else's lead never does.

Honour Capture: When an Honour wins a trick, the owner of each other Honour in it pays the trick's winner **2 chips**. With three Honours in a trick, each captured Honour pays separately.

Pagat Ultimo: When a Pagat wins the **12th trick**, each opponent of the winner pays them **1 chip**. A lone Declarer pays **3 chips** instead, the same as they would collect.

When a Pagat loses the 12th trick, its owner pays the trick's winner **2 chips**, if they are opponents. A Pagat still in hand is always played to the 12th trick, so keeping a Pagat to the end is always an attempt. This combines with Honour Capture. If a Mond captures a Pagat in the 12th trick, the Pagat's owner pays the winner 2 chips for each moment, 4 in total.

A Pagat Ultimo, won or lost, is never held. If the sides are still hidden, pay it at the end of the deal.

Example: A is the Declarer and calls the King of hearts. B leads the King of clubs, C plays the Queen of clubs, and D trumps and wins the trick. For the Fallen King, B places 1 chip in front of them toward D. For the Queen's Ransom, C does the same. Later, C plays the King of hearts, so C is A's partner, and B and D are the Defenders. C hands their chip to D, and B takes theirs back.

Example: B leads a black 5, C plays a Fool, and A, the Declarer, plays the other Fool. C's Fool was played first, so it wins and captures A's Fool. A places 2 chips in front of them toward C. If C turns out to be A's partner, A takes them back. Otherwise, C gets them.

Counting

In a Point game, count the card points of the Declarer's side after the last trick: all cards in their trick piles, including the Declarer's discards and any talon cards that count for them, plus 1 for each trick they won. The Defenders' card points are 76 minus that total. The Declarer's side wins with 39 card points or more.

Tip: Count the smaller pile. Pull out the Honours, Kings, Queens, Jacks, and 10s, add up their card points, and add 1 for each trick. If it is the Defenders' pile, subtract the total from 76.

Settling

At the end of each deal, the game is settled between the sides.

Game value: Start with the **bid value** (Table 2) and add the **margin** from Table 4: find the card points of the Declarer's side in the row for a won or a lost game, and read the margin above.

Table 4: Margin

Margin	0	1	2	3	4
Won	39–44	45–50	51–56	57–62	63+
Lost	33–38	27–32	21–26	15–20	0–14

Payment: If the Declarer's side won the game, the Defenders pay the game value. If it lost, the Declarer's side pays it.

- **With a partner:** each Defender settles with one player of the Declarer's side, so every player wins or loses the game value once.
- **Alone:** the Declarer settles with each of the three Defenders.

Example: A plays Two with C as partner, and together they take 51 card points. The margin is 2, so the game value is $4 + 2 = 6$. B pays A 6 chips, and D pays C 6 chips. Had A played alone, B, C, and D would each have paid A 6 chips.

Ramsch

If all four players pass, everyone plays alone and tries to take as few card points as possible. The negative rules apply (see Trick Play), and Forehand leads.

Gifts: The winner of each of the first six tricks also takes the top card of the talon, shows it, and adds it to their trick pile. The gift has its normal card points but is not part of the trick.

Payment: Everyone counts their own card points, including 1 for each trick they won. Each player pays **2 chips** to every player with fewer card points. Players with equal card points pay each other nothing.

Example: A takes 30 card points, B 24, C 14, and D 8. A pays 2 chips each to B, C, and D. B pays 2 each to C and D, and C pays 2 to D. In total, A loses 6, B loses 2,

C wins 2, and D wins 6.

Keeping Score

With poker chips: If you have to pay more chips than you have, borrow 10 chips from the bank, as often as you need. Note what you borrowed. If the bank runs out, note further loans on paper.

On paper: Write one column per player. Everyone starts at 0, and scores may go below 0. Each chip is one point on the score sheet. During the deal, note each moment payment, for example "A +1, B −1". Circle the entries made before the called King is played. Once it is played, cross out circled entries between players on the same side. After the deal, add the game payment and write each player's change for the deal in one row. Every row adds up to 0, which shows a mistake at once. Keep a running total for each player.

Match End

The match ends after 3 rounds. With poker chips, subtract any loans from your chip total. Totals may be below 0.

The player with the most chips wins. If players are tied, they share the win.

Design Notes and Credits

Jugglin is inspired by the Tarock games Slovenian Tarok, Königrufen, and Danish Grosstarock. I learned about them in Jerry Neill Furr's Tarocchi, written under the name Philebus. Further inspiration came from Skat, Doppelkopf, and Sean Ross's Beaver Tail.

Special thanks to all playtesters and everyone who helped improve Jugglin, especially Tanja Simic, Matthias Gilch, and Max Paulenz.

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JUGGLiN **Player Reference** For Four Players • Version 0.2

A Deal at a Glance

1. **Deal:** 6 cards face down as the talon, then 12 cards to each player.
2. **Auction:** Forehand first. Bid higher (Three, Two, One, Zero) or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.
3. **Talon:** In Three, Two, or One, turn it face up. The Declarer takes a group and discards as many cards, tarocks face up. The rest, or the whole talon in Zero, counts for the Defenders. In Ramsch, it stays face down.
4. **Partner:** The Declarer calls a King. Its holder becomes their secret partner.
5. **Tricks:** Forehand leads. In a Point game, pay the moments after each trick. After the trick with the called King, partners exchange one card.
6. **Settling:** The sides settle the game. In Ramsch, each player pays everyone with fewer card points.

Cards

Tarocks: Jokers (Fools), black Aces (Monds), 5–2 by number, red Aces (Pagats). Same number: black beats red. A Pagat beats a Fool.
Twins: the same number and colour, or both Jokers. The first played ranks higher.
Honours: two Fools, two Monds, and two Pagats. An Honour that wins a trick captures every other Honour in it.
Suits: King, Queen, Jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6.

Card	Card points
Honours: Fools, Monds, Pagats	4
King	4
Queen	3
Jack	2
10	1
Any other card	0
Each trick won	1
Total	76

Auction

Bid higher or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.

Bid	Talon cards	Bid value
Three	3	2
Two	2	4
One	1	6
Zero	None	10

Talon

Three, Two, One: Turn the talon face up, take a group, and discard as many. Never discard Kings or Honours. Discard tarocks face up. The rest counts for the Defenders.
Zero: The talon counts unseen for the Defenders, or for the Declarer if the called King is in it.
Ramsch: The talon stays face down until the gifts are taken.

Point Game

The Declarer's side needs 39 card points.
Calling a King: The holder of the called King is the Declarer's silent partner. Calling your own King, or a King in the talon, means playing alone. The sides become known when the called King is played. After that trick, the partners on each side exchange one card face down, unless the Declarer plays alone.

Trick Play

Follow suit. If you cannot, play a tarock. If you can do neither, play any card. A tarock played to a led tarock follows suit.
Negative rules (Ramsch): Beat the trick so far if you can. Play a Pagat only onto a Fool with no Pagat in the trick yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats, also when leading.

Moments

Point games only. Paid to the trick's winner by its opponents. Until the called King is played, hold the chips in front of you, toward the winner. Then hand them to opponents and take back the rest.

Moment	In a trick	Payment
Queen's Ransom	A King and the Queen of its suit.	The Queen's owner pays 1.
Fallen King	A led King, won by another player.	Its owner pays 1.
Honour Capture	An Honour captured by another Honour.	Its owner pays 2.
Pagat Ultimo	A Pagat in the 12th trick.	If it wins, each opponent pays 1, a lone Declarer 3. If it loses, its owner pays 2.

Settling

Game value: The bid value plus the margin.
With a partner: each Defender settles with one player of the Declarer's side. **Alone:** the Declarer settles with each Defender.

Margin	0	1	2	3	4
Won	39–44	45–50	51–56	57–62	63+
Lost	33–38	27–32	21–26	15–20	0–14

Ramsch

Everyone plays alone, and Forehand leads. The winners of the first six tricks each take a talon card as a gift. Each player pays 2 to every player with fewer card points.

Keeping Score

Poker chips: borrow 10 from the bank as often as needed. Subtract loans at match end.
Paper: one column per player, starting at 0. Every deal's row adds up to 0.

Match End

3 rounds, so 12 deals. The most chips wins.

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Game Board

Put a coin on the contract. Every payment goes directly from player to player.

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Contract

Bid for talon cards, then call a King.

Bid (talon cards taken)	Three	Two	One	Zero
	3 talon cards	2 talon cards	1 talon card	no talon cards
Point game (39 or more card points)	2 + margin	4 + margin	6 + margin	10 + margin
Ramsch (if all pass)	Each player pays **2** to every player with fewer card points.			

Calling a King: its holder is the silent partner, unless it is your own King or in the talon. Until it is played, hold moment chips toward the winner.

Exchange: after the trick with the called King, the partners on each side exchange one card face down, unless the Declarer plays alone.

Three, Two, One: take a talon group and discard as many, never Kings or Honours, tarocks face up. The rest counts for the Defenders.

Zero: the talon counts unseen for the Defenders, or for the Declarer if the called King is in it.

Ramsch: the winners of the first six tricks each take the top talon card.

Cards and Tricks

Juggler's Trick

A Pagat wins every trick that holds a Fool.

Tarocks, high to low — **Honours:** Fools, Monds, Pagats

Joker ★★	A ♣♣	5 ♣♣	5 ♥♦	4 ♣♣	4 ♥♦	3 ♣♣	3 ♥♦	2 ♣♣	2 ♥♦	A ♥♦
4	4									4
Fools	*Monds*									*Pagats*

Suit cards — ● card points

K	Q	J	10	9	8	7	6
4	3	2	1				

Each trick 1 — 12 tricks

Twins: the same number and colour, or both Jokers. The first played ranks higher.

Tricks: follow suit, else a tarock, else any card.

Negative rules (Ramsch): beat the trick so far if you can. Play a Pagat only onto a Fool with no Pagat in the trick yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats, also when leading.

Moments

Point games only. Paid to the trick's winner by its opponents.

Queen's Ransom — 1

A King and the Queen of its suit. The Queen's owner pays.

Fallen King — 1

A led King, won by another player. Its owner pays.

Honour Capture — 2

An Honour captured by another Honour. Its owner pays.

Pagat Ultimo — 2

A Pagat in the 12th trick.
Wins: 1 from each opponent, 3 from a lone Declarer.
Loses: its owner pays 2.

Settling

76 card points: 64 on the cards, 12 for tricks. The Declarer's side needs **39**. Discards count as cards, never as tricks.

Margin by the Declarer's card points

Won	39–44 **0**	45–50 **1**	51–56 **2**	57–62 **3**	63+ **4**
Lost	33–38 **0**	27–32 **1**	21–26 **2**	15–20 **3**	0–14 **4**

Game value: the number in the contract cell plus the margin. Each Defender settles it with one player of the Declarer's side, or with a lone Declarer.

Out of chips: borrow 10 from the bank, and subtract it at match end. **No poker chips:** keep score on paper, where every deal adds up to 0.